

Threat Actors & Their Motivations

Know Your Enemy

Security without a threat model is decoration. You must understand WHO might attack you and WHY – because the "who" dictates the "how hard they'll try".

The Main Actor Types

Actor	Motivation	Sophistication	Persistence
Cybercriminals	Money	Low-Med	Medium
Nation-state (APT)	Espionage, sabotage	Very High	Extreme
Hacktivists	Ideology, chaos	Low-Med	Low
Insiders	Money, revenge, espionage	Varies	Varies
Script kiddies	Notoriety, learning	Low	Low
Terrorists	Disruption	Med	Low
Competitors	Economic espionage	Med-High	High

Nation-State / APT

Advanced Persistent Threats. Slow, quiet, patient.

Rely on **dwell time** – staying hidden inside networks for months

Use **zero-days** and custom malware

Abuse legitimate tools (living off the land – PowerShell, WMI, LOLBins)

Objective is usually espionage OR preparing sabotage (ICS)

APT playbook: Initial access (phish or exploit) → establish persistence → enumerate → move laterally → collect target data → exfiltrate stealthily.

Cybercriminals & Ransomware Gangs

Business model: ransomware as a service (RaaS). Affiliates do the attacks, operators take a cut. This industrialized model is why ransomware exploded – anyone can "buy" a capable attack.

Profile: opportunistic at first, increasingly surgical (they research your backups and negotiate based on your insurance).

Hacktivists & DDoS for a Cause

Ideology-driven: DDoS, defacement, data leaks. Targets: govt sites, corporations they dislike. Lower sophistication, loud, not patient.

Insiders

The insider threat is always among the hardest:

Malicious – disgruntled, bribed, recruited

Negligent – clicks phishing, weak passwords (the most common)

Compromised – attacker logs in as them via phishing

Detection: impossible to prevent perfectly. You detect via anomalies: user accessing abnormal systems, exfil volumes, off-hours logins.

Modeling: The Diamond Model

The Diamond Model frames intrusion events as four vertices:

Adversary – who

Capability – what tool/technique

Infrastructure – what C2/servers

Victim – who/what is targeted

Every intrusion sits inside that diamond. Using it to communicate makes you sound (and think) like an analyst.

[← The CIA Triad & Beyond](#)

[Risk Management & Threat Model...](#)